

Eagles as Critical Transport Infrastructure: Why We Can't Just Fly Everywhere

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No question is put to this author more often, at conferences and in taverns, than the Eagle Question: *why didn't you simply fly?* The question is understandable and the answer is institutional, so naturally nobody stays for it. Here it is in writing.

1 Infrastructure with sovereignty

The Great Eagles present as transport capacity: heavy-lift, all-weather, unmatched speed over hostile terrain. The error is to model them as *infrastructure*, when they are in fact a *sovereign provider* — a self-governing polity that occasionally, at its own discretion, performs airlift.

The distinction is everything. Infrastructure has a schedule and a price. A sovereign provider has interests, risk tolerances, and the right of refusal. There is no contract, no tariff, no service-level agreement — every Eagle intervention on record is a *gift*, and gift economies do not scale into logistics networks.

2 The airspace problem

Even granting goodwill, the corridor analysis is grim. A direct flight to the objective traverses continuously surveilled airspace defended by interceptors specifically bred for the role. Strategic transport that must survive contested airspace is not transport; it is an air campaign, with an air campaign's probability of success and an air campaign's tendency to announce itself.

The historical uses of Eagle capacity — extraction of stranded persons from towers, pinnacles, and volcanoes — share a profile: short duration, low predictability, terminal urgency. This is search-and-rescue, and search-and-rescue is precisely the mission gift-economy capacity is good for.

3 The policy failure worth naming

The real lesson is that Middle-earth's Free Peoples never built the boring alternative: roads. Reliable, dull, contract-governed surface logistics would have changed more outcomes than any eagle. Civilisations are tempted to solve infrastructure gaps with heroic capacity — the sovereign provider that shows up at the last moment — because heroes are cheaper than maintenance budgets, right up until they decline the mission.

Build the roads. Thank the Eagles. Do not confuse the two.